

Adaptation and Resistance: The Phased Evolution of Feminist Activism in an Authoritarian Era

Lü Pin

Introduction

The emergence of feminism in China stemmed from the dual impact of Reform and Opening on women's position in society. While economic marketization exposed women's vulnerabilities amid inadequate rights protection (Brusseovich, Dabla-Norris & Li, 2021; Cartier & Rothenberg-Aalami, 1999; Min, 2005), urban, highly educated women simultaneously gained unprecedented autonomy within an increasingly complex society, as the state's capacity to control social dynamics diminished (Cai, 2020; Johnston, 2012, 2019). The first civil women's organization in China was established in 1988, but it was the Fourth World Conference on Women held in Beijing in 1995 that is recognized as having catalyzed the rise of the feminist movement in China. Over the past three decades, the movement has managed not only to persist but also to expand amid strengthening authoritarian rule.

This chapter provides a historical analysis of China's feminist movement from 1995 onward through a comparison of three strategic phases: 1995-2010, 2012-2015, and 2018-2020. The analytical framework draws on political process theory in social movement research, which conceptualizes social movements as dynamic processes engaging the external environment, while accounting for the specific context of feminism in an authoritarian setting. Four key analytical concepts from political process theory are employed to structure the analysis: political opportunity structure, mobilization structure, framing, and repertoire

(Gelb, & Hart, 1999; McAdam, 2003; McAdam, Tarrow, 1998; Tarrow & Tilly, 2003).

Political opportunity structure consists of external factors shaping the emergence of social movements. This study examines state responses to feminist movements — tolerance, suppression, facilitation (Chen, 2020) — as a key aspect, analyzing these shifts against regime interests and capacities, while considering mediating variables like civil society, media, and internet spheres. Mobilization structure, repertoire, and framing constitute three key dimensions of social movement strategy. These describe how movements develop leadership, organization, and networks to facilitate participation; how they construct discourses to diagnose problems, propose solutions, and motivate support; and the effective patterns through which they deploy tactical interventions, respectively. The analysis of these three conceptual dimensions across each phase of the feminist movement illuminates how movement strategies evolved in practice. Rather than merely reflecting the conscious choices of movement actors, strategy represents an accumulation of pragmatic adaptations shaped by the movement's structural position within the political context, though individual agency remains significant (Beckwith, 2007; Lichbach, 1987; McCammon, 2012). As the relational dynamics between movement actors and state institutions shifted from embedded to external and even confrontational, the three dimensions of feminist movement strategy and their configuration underwent corresponding transformations. Feminist movement strategies have been gendered, strategically leveraging, negotiating, and transforming societal constructions of women's identity, position, and experience (Beckwith, 2007; Joshi, 2022, Staggenborg & Taylor, 2005).

This study also evaluates the achievements of each phase of China's feminist movement. While successfully advancing legal and political reforms usually stands as the most visible achievement of a movement, Amenta, Caren, Chiarello, and Su (2010) argue that such reforms represent only intermediate-level change. The structural consequences of a movement— specifically, its capacity to 'provide a group with continuing leverage over political processes and increase the political returns to collective action' constitutes a more fundamental measure of success (Amenta et al., 2010). From this perspective, this study

evaluates how the feminist movement contributed to women's empowerment and transformed gender-related agendas among both public and state actors, with particular attention to the sustainability of these changes. This study ultimately aims beyond merely documenting the trajectory of China's feminist movement and seeks to crystalize and theorize lessons derived from movement-state interactions under authoritarianism while acknowledging that a single analysis cannot fully capture the struggles and sacrifices of multiple generations of feminists.

1995–2010: Embedded Scholar-Activists at the Margins of the System

In the mid 1990s, under Jiang Zemin's leadership, the state actively acknowledged Western superiority in knowledge, technology, and capital while addressing developmental challenges through strategic learning and capital importation (Gallagher, 2002). The Fourth World Conference on Women created the initial political opportunity for China's feminist movement by introducing two fundamental concepts. First, a unique gender perspective distinguished itself from the government's rhetoric of "equality between men and women" by emphasizing structural critique. Second, the NGO framework legitimized civil society action autonomous from the state domain (Spires, 2011; Wang & Zhang, 2010; Zhang, 2020). Inspiration drawn from these "advanced Western ideas" was primarily confined to a select group of women intellectuals employed within state-sponsored cultural, educational, and research institutions (Beckwith, 2000; Milwertz & Bu, 2007; Min, 2005; Wang, 1997). They combined sincere enthusiasm for women's rights with aspirations to expand their professional expertise through feminist engagement in addressing China's gender issues. The innovators of Women's Media Watch Network, China's first media and gender action group that was created several months after the World Conference on Women, recalled:

The Conference slogan "Looking at the World through Women's Eyes", visible everywhere during the conference, boosted our determination to correct collectively the many mistakes in the media's reports on women. We wanted to promote equal sharing between women and men of the

media, and we wanted to build a media environment favorable to women's struggle for equality and development (Cai, Feng, & Guo, 2020, p. 213).

After the Conference momentum subsided, it became apparent that civil feminist activism remained strictly constrained by the limitations of legal status and could not access resources allocated within the state's system. Nevertheless, the government maintained a tacit, even tolerant attitude toward feminism, largely due to its own lack of resources and capacity to address social issues, including women's concerns. The decentralization of the Party-state's power structure also allowed feminists familiar with the system to find opportunities to navigate and exploit certain gaps, provided they did not cross the line of political opposition (Nathan, 2009; Scoggins, 2021). International foundations provided funding enabling feminist scholars to establish themselves as gender experts and pursue their independent agendas, while also collaborating with government entities, particularly at the local level, that urgently needed funding and expertise.

By the early 2000s, the strategic approach of the feminist movement had taken shape. The organizational infrastructure centered on a few established organizations, typically coordinated by respected senior scholar-activists who maintained deep connections across the Women's Federation, government, academia, and international foundations. One of the leading organizations during this period was the Anti-Domestic Violence Network (ADV) in Beijing, which was affiliated with the China Law Society and supported by substantial, decade-long funding from foundations led by the Ford Foundation. ADV established a nationwide umbrella structure encompassing over 70 network members across 28 provinces at its peak, including numerous local governmental institutions such as women's federations, law enforcement agencies, and judicial bodies. Nationwide, key networks were organized around three central themes: domestic violence, gender and development (GAD), and women's/gender studies, incorporating interdisciplinary gender scholars (Milwertz, 2003; Zhang & Hsiung, 2010). Training sessions of varying scale and scope, along with conferences and collective projects, continued to maintain and strengthen these networks. For instance, under the GAD theme, multiple independent mechanisms emerged, including local GAD groups in various locations, a national GAD network comprising 40 member organizations, a long-running

monthly sharing gathering in Beijing, and an email group with more than 1,000 members that encompassed the majority of feminists.

During this period, the feminist movement's core framing emphasized the validity of feminist conceptualizations of women's rights in alignment with international standards, thereby asserting the necessity for the state agenda to incorporate feminist ideas for self-improvement. Scholar-activists attributed the cause of contemporary problems to historical, cultural, and institutional factors, framing institutional deficiencies as stemming from specific structural imbalances and developmental limitations rather than systemic state failures (Greenhalgh, 2002). They advocated for multi-level legal and political reforms, complemented by gender awareness initiatives and capacity-building programs for state actors, alongside institutional strengthening to enhance bureaucratic protection for women. The value of their advocacy was exemplified in three key ways: their initiatives were grounded in well-researched empirical evidence; their proposals were aligned with internationally recognized standards and best practices; and the advancement of women's rights was intended to contribute to national objectives of harmony and stability, even while requiring state adaptation.

The movement's three primary repertoires drew from and connected international development projects with academic research methodologies, leveraging activists' professional and social capital. First, capacity-building training targeted key stakeholders — including professionals, government officials, and community members — who were identified as crucial for project success. Training aimed to reshape participants' conceptual frameworks while enhancing their practical capacity to address gender-related challenges. The second approach involved evidence-based advocacy for legal and policy reform, following a three-step process: empirically demonstrating problem severity through field research; systematically evaluating existing legal and policy frameworks to identify gaps; and professionally formulating and publicly submitting reform proposals to decision-making bodies. Proposals were strategically released during legislative windows, such as the “Two Sessions” or through independent symposia with media coverage. The third approach centered on demonstration projects, which concentrated resources at specific sites to implement and evaluate feminist intervention concepts, aiming to develop documented best practices supporting advocacy. For example,

ADVNI conducted long-term pilot projects in Beijing and Hunan to validate their proposed multi-agency intervention model for addressing domestic violence.

One leader's articulation of integrated "top-down" and "bottom-up" approaches reflected the movement's embedded characteristics (Ho & Edmonds, 2008) that manifested in two aspects: maintaining feminist principles and independent agenda-setting, while emphasizing pragmatic efforts to negotiate advancement within existing power structures (Keech-Marx, 2014; Teets, 2013; Wang & Zhang, 2010). The successful advocacy for anti-domestic violence legislation represented the feminist movement's most significant achievement during this period, as an example of its strategy of negotiating with the state through institutional collaboration (Jiang & Zhou, 2021; Kaufman, 2012).

Beyond specific legislative victories, one of the feminist movement's most profound historical impacts lay in creating an alternative public sphere for women's rights. Within this sphere, scholar-activists pioneered the imagination and exploration of autonomy from the state, even if they were unable to fully realize their vision. In this regard, even their public embrace of feminism and NGO principles carried significant meaning. They devoted extensive efforts to examining diverse women's issues, simultaneously engaging with international feminist discourses while tracking both rights violations against Chinese women and related institutional problems. Their work generated a series of localized rights-based demands that served as enduring foundations for advocacy. Although limited in size, the national network that actively reinforced connections between academic and activist domains established recognized gender expertise, enabling sustained dialogue with state agencies and women's federations, thereby positioning themselves as authoritative voices in ongoing negotiations over state practices (Hsiung, 2021; Keech-Marx, 2014). On the other hand, the movement was confined to a circle of elite women and became vulnerable due to its dependence on institutional connections.

In the late 2000s, China witnessed a significant expansion of civil society, marked by the marketization of media, the rise of independent and critical civic initiatives, and the proliferation of active online discourse (Hildebrandt, 2013; Huhe, Tang & Chen, 2018; Lei,

2016). Civil society developments largely disconnected from feminism in practice, with the notable exception of interventions in high-profile social events by Guangdong-based feminist scholar Ai Xiaoming and her students and assistants at Sun Yat-Sen University. While more feminist activists and organizations recognized the shifting context and began contemplating strategies for public advocacy, they lacked sufficient impetus to transform their operational models. In 2010, ADVN's institutional affiliation with the China Law Society was terminated, symbolically marking the end of this era.

2012–2015: Public Advocacy by Young Activism

In the early 2010s, feminist ideas gained greater prominence among young people whose tertiary education facilitated migration to urban centers, where they encountered digital connectivity and dynamic social environments. For this cohort, feminism served both as an epistemological framework offering critical perspectives on personal and societal phenomena, and as a pathway to empowerment through transformative action within social structures that traditionally marginalized young women's voices (Wang, 2020). At this time, civil society organizations proliferated at an unprecedented rate, enhancing societal awareness of marginalized groups and channeling their demands. Mass media emerged as a significant potential ally, with successful organizations achieving substantial market penetration and influence through their coverage of controversial issues despite censorship (Lei, 2016). These developments signaled potential opportunities for the feminist movement, contingent upon strategic engagement with emerging socio-political spaces.

The feminist movement's strategic transformation during 2012-2015 emerged specifically from the collaboration between two established civil society organizations: Yirenping and Feminist Voices. Yirenping, founded in 2006, brought extensive advocacy experience from various rights domains, possessing comprehensive strategic frameworks, operational expertise, cross-sectoral volunteer networks, media connections, substantial financial resources, and multi-city administrative systems (Fu, 2013; Lu, 2021). Feminist Voices, transformed from Women's Media Watch Network in 2009, through its integrated online platforms and Beijing-based activity center, had cultivated a significant young feminist following and uniquely

positioned young activists as the movement's future direction. The movement's new phase was inaugurated on February 14, 2012, with 'The Wounded Bride' action in Beijing. Supported by both organizations, three activists in blood-stained wedding dresses conducted a protest march along Qianmen Street, displaying anti-domestic violence messages despite police intervention. This action marked the emergence of "Young Feminist Activism" (YFA) under young activist leadership.

YFA's organizational infrastructure centered on dedicated activists connected to Yirenping and Feminist Voices. Through these activists as nodes, and through frequent training, actions, and networking, the movement established extensive volunteer networks, primarily comprising university students. Local groups in major metropolitan centers actively organized initiatives while building connections with other social movements. Two initiatives represented YFA's approach to integrating identity formation, ideological development, and organizational capacity: Yirenping's Feminist Camps across major cities and Feminist Voices' Feminist School in Beijing, conducted with scholar-activists. The multi-day Feminist Camps attracted dozens of volunteers from nearby regions interested in feminism and activism. Participants engaged in intensive learning of feminist theory, civil society principles, and activist methods, culminating in the planning and implementation of collective action. The Feminist School offered an advanced eight-weekend summer course for experienced young activists. Rather than providing practical gender training or theoretical studies, it integrated cutting-edge feminist knowledge and radical critical concepts with real-world issues, fostering the critical leadership capacity of YFA's core organizers.

YFA explicitly departed from the moderate, institutional negotiation approach of senior scholar-activists (Wang, 2018a, 2018b, 2018c). As one member articulated:

Some friends advise us to advance our cause by 'quietly' lobbying the government... Many women before us have taken the accommodationist route, but little has changed. Strong public pressure is necessary. We cannot afford to go about our campaign quietly (Xiao, May 14, 2015).

YFA's action repertoire comprised three interconnected components. First, they mobilized

stakeholder representatives before the public, while these representatives maintained strategic anonymity regarding their organizational affiliations. Second, they implemented coordinated collective action incorporating public mobilization and accountability mechanisms. Third, they deployed sophisticated media engagement strategies calibrated to align with media interests and maximize coverage. Their tactics encompassed various forms of contention, including petitions, public interest litigation, and street demonstrations. The last one was strategically reframed as “performance art” to navigate the restrictive political-legal environment of the Chinese context (Wei, 2014).

YFA viewed strategic and also pragmatic engagement with the public as a crucial part of their work, with deliberate attention to communication effectiveness. Core members of YFA also frequently engaged in media interviews and delivered speeches at universities and public venues, as their opportunities to comprehensively construct and convey their messaging to gain resonance. Rather than engaging in an in-depth analysis of gender inequality, they primarily appealed to emotional mobilization, focusing not on women’s suffering but on the activists’ passion, courage, and sense of achievement, using themselves as examples while leveraging their personal appeal and charisma. Members of YFA and their regular media contacts were well aware that portraying organized collective action as spontaneous individual acts was a facade, as was their selective promotion of a few prominent activists - a deliberate coordination of performance. De-organization of the movement within their framing served to safeguard the rightfulness of resistance (Fu, 2018; O’Brien & Li, 2006), while the emphasis on individuals demonstrated symbolic rewards and encouraged emulation.

YFA’s strategic innovation lay in how it astutely grasped the changes in the late Hu Jintao era — namely, the favorable environment for extra-institutional civil society under relative state tolerance, as well as the transformative potential of young feminists. YFA demonstrated remarkable operational efficiency through their frequent and diverse actions, which were particularly noteworthy given their limited financial resources and small core membership. Within just three years, they achieved some key policy changes directly affecting women’s interests, such as gender discrimination in college admissions, unequal space for men and women in public toilets, and the detention of sex workers. They also

changed the orientation of some influential sex cases to be more favorable to women. Some other women's rights issues, such as sexual harassment and gender discrimination in recruitment, were only brought into the public arena for the first time as a result of YFA's efforts, despite their long-standing existence. On a broader scale, YFA succeeded in bringing feminist discourse into mainstream social consciousness, integrating feminist perspectives into public debate and demonstrating the movement's capacity to navigate state authority boundaries. Most significantly, YFA pioneered embodied forms of protest and provocative visual expressions concerning gender and sexuality, generating watershed moments for the movement while probing the gendered constraints of the authoritarian-patriarchal system (Leggett, 2017; Tan, 2017, 2023).

Despite its impact, YFA remained limited in scope rather than developing into a broad-based movement. Its NGO origins resulted in a hierarchical structure dependent on singular funding sources and characterized by a small core of active participants. While segments of the public were aware of their activities, actual engagement remained constrained, largely due to their primary reliance on mass media channels for communication and their limited presence on social media platforms. YFA's approach of designing actions around media impact increasingly generated concern about maintaining sufficient creative appeal to attract attention. While the movement remained marginal, YFA's leaders became aware of increasing risks of repression. In February 2015, one member wrote: "The government has recognized the subversive and organizational potential of feminist movement mobilization methods, and has therefore identified certain individuals" (Liang, personal communication, February 3, 2015).

Xi Jinping's ascension to power in November 2012 did not mark an abrupt shift in the Party-state's stance toward civil society but rather signaled the beginning of a progressively more restrictive phase. Beginning in 2014, civil society organizations and their leaders faced increasing suppression. In March 2015, five core YFA members, all full-time NGO employees with three working for Yirenping, were detained in multiple cities for planning an anti-sexual harassment campaign on public transit systems. Their subsequent 37-day detention became known as the "Feminist Five" case, which deeply shocked both the feminist community and civil society at large. Although the five activists were released following intense domestic and

international advocacy, the impact of the case was far-reaching. Several related NGOs, including Yirenping, were forced to either shut down or operate underground. While some core organizers were compelled to abandon their roles, and although some activists and Feminist Voices continued their activities, they faced constant surveillance that severely curtailed their operational capacity. Simultaneously, mainstream media, which had already experienced suppression, virtually ceased covering their activities. March 2015 can be considered the effective end of the strategic phase of the feminist movement led by YFA.

2018–2020: The Mass Emotional Mobilization of #MeToo

The transition to Xi Jinping's leadership marked the conclusion of a period of relatively moderate authoritarian governance, a shift that scholars attribute to two key factors: his apparent belief that the more restrained approach under Hu Jintao could precipitate a crisis of political authority, and his personal aspirations for greater power consolidation (Minzner, 2018; Shirk, 2018). Civil society began to face a series of harsh crackdowns. Repressive actions were characterized by four major coordinated forms: the criminalization of leading organizations and their leaders; public political stigmatization campaigns; daily surveillance, harassment, and persecution of organizations, activists, and their activities; and widespread censorship (Chen, 2020; Fu & Distelhorst, 2018; Ivan & Elisia, 2018; Jiang, 2021; Zhu & Lu, 2022). Following multiple rounds of criminal crackdowns and other forms of suppression, many major civil society movements lost their resilience in this period (Gullotta & Lin, 2023; O'Brien, 2023; Tian & Chuang, 2022).

During this period, the political space for feminist movements also experienced unprecedented constriction. In March 2018, Feminist Voices was banned and ceased public activities under direct police pressure. Subsequently, the feminist movement no longer had any leading advocacy organizations and retained only a few providers of professional support and community service. Feminist activists who persisted, including some core members of YFA, paid a heavy price due to continuous daily persecution, leading them to increasingly reduce their semi-underground activities. After May 2017, when the All-China Women's Federation publicly distanced itself from 'Western feminism,' feminism faced increasing stigmatization in

public discourse, being labeled as ‘extreme’, ‘reactionary’, and ‘disruptive to order’ (Liao, 2024; Lu, 2019). In mainstream media, feminist movements became increasingly difficult to cover — even the most high-profile events were either blocked from publication or quickly deleted. On social media, feminist accounts could be deleted by the hundreds under the pretext of ‘inciting gender antagonism’. Yet, the feminist movement seized one important opportunity: the proliferation of social media (Earl, 2015; Huhe, Tang & Chen, 2018) and the narrowing of the digital gender gap in urban populations had created an unprecedented space for online activism.

In early January 2018, a new stage of the feminist movement, #MeToo started on the internet when Luo Xixi, a PhD graduate, publicly accused her former advisor at a prestigious university of a prolonged period of sexual harassment. At the end of July 2018, #MeToo had expanded from education to the workplace with the exposure of numerous high-profile figures in public service and culture accused of sexual harassment. During this significant month, 22 cases captured headlines, each revealed through survivors sharing their personal experiences on social media (Huang, 2020). That year saw the public exposure of over 40 university professors and public figures accused of sexual harassment.

The rise of #MeToo in the face of repression demonstrated the effectiveness of its unprecedented strategies in addressing the interrelated challenges of the dissolution of organizing, diminishing legitimacy, and the difficulty of forming collective action. #MeToo no longer maintained a tight organizational structure centered on the leadership of social movement entrepreneurs. Instead, it manifested as a vast yet decentralized and connective network (Gu & Heemsbergen, 2023; Zeng, 2020), consisting of many small and less high-profile units, upheld by many emerging organizers who had no NGO background. For example, around survivors who spoke out, an informal but tightly knit support group was often quickly formed. While group members may not have known each other in person, they typically had established online connections and possessed relevant experience. Within these groups, supporters provided close companionship, offered advice on managing public opinion and accessing legal resources, and facilitated connections to various forms of support. Xianzi, a young woman who joined #MeToo after exposing the sexual harassment of a famous TV host

in July 2018, is one such example. An observer wrote:

Xianzi has helped at least 10 victims. The help depends on the needs of the victims themselves. If someone wants to file a lawsuit, Xianzi would help to contact a reliable lawyer; if someone wants to have media coverage, Xianzi would help to contact media reporters. More often than not, the victims may not be able to do anything, or may not want to do anything, so Xianzi would just accompany and chat with them (Lin, 2020).

The feminist discourse on social media demonstrated remarkable vibrancy at the time despite potential disruptions or terminations due to censorship and cyber violence (Gunitsky, 2015; Liao, 2023; Repnikova & Fang, 2018). The expanding affordances of social media platforms increasingly accommodated longer posts with diverse forms of expression. Such posts featuring deep and authentic emotional storytelling and elaboration were thus able to function as crucial nodes for the formation of resonance (Guttenberg, 2021; Huang, 2021; Li, Cho, Qin & Chen, 2021; Lin & Yang, 2019, 2001). On 24 April 2019, in response to the stigmatization of victims in the rape case of billionaire Richard Liu, a group of feminists initiated the hashtag “I’m not a Perfect Victim Either” on Weibo. The launch statement encouraged people to share their relevant experiences, challenge rape culture conventions, and dispel society’s myths about the ‘perfect victim’. Within just two weeks, the hashtag garnered 20,000 comments and 16 million hits, with many commenters disclosing their experiences with sexual assault for the first time. One observer noted the effect of this hashtag was that “a flood of powerful and painful stories came together to blunt the sharp edges of rape culture” (Xiao, 2019).

Collective action became feasible only when individual instances of sexual violence incited substantial public outrage, enabling organizers to rapidly gather a large participant base before facing suppression (Goodwin & Pfaff, 2001; Jasper, 2011). In May 2020, in response to

an allegation of rape made by a minor girl against her adoptive father, YFA's activists anonymously initiated a petition to prohibit adults with educational, custodial, and parental responsibilities from engaging in sexual activity with minors. Organizers converted the link to the petition page into a QR code embedded in a vibrant mobile-friendly image, enabling one-click access and participation. The image also strategically included the signup deadline, target mobilization numbers, and periodic updates on the percentage of targets achieved, serving as a call to action. After being shared with multiple feminist groups, the image was swiftly and organically proliferated in a chain-reaction style to a broader audience. Despite most participants in the chain of mobilization and petition signing being unaware of the original initiators and with minimal traceability online, the petition remarkably amassed a record 65,000 signatures. The petition notched a significant victory when, apparently spurred by the public opinion it fostered, the National People's Congress (NPC), China's highest legislative body, resolved in October of that year to integrate a pertinent provision in the Penal Code revision.

On 2 December 2020, the first trial in Xianzi's sexual harassment case took place in a Beijing court. On the day of the trial, hundreds of individuals gathered outside the courtroom, some bravely confronting police while holding pro-#MeToo signs. Six social media groups, each maxing out at 500 members, were swiftly set up to facilitate access to updates from the site and express their support. Live images, videos, and narratives were promptly spread across social media. An activist involved in the event subsequently characterized it as a manifestation of a "utopian experience of civil society" (Wei, 2020). The Xianzi trial demonstrated the movement's capacity to generate collective mobilization even in an environment where such actions seemed nearly impossible.

The policy changes brought about by #MeToo primarily occurred in the educational sphere (Liao & Luqiu, 2022). Although the advocated mechanisms for preventing sexual harassment in universities had not been established, university teachers were prohibited from having intimate relationships with students and faced severe punishment for violations. In departments closer to power centers, such as police and judicial systems, there remained strong rejections to feminist propositions. #MeToo's greater achievement lay in its transformation of society and the population. While many other social controversies subsided, debates on women's rights

intensified and attracted such attention that they even led the public agenda — an outcome previously unimaginable. #MeToo led countless individuals to embrace feminism, with many recognizing this as a confrontational value choice and choosing to integrate feminism into their personal life decisions. As feminism evolved into a widespread cultural and lifestyle phenomenon, diffusing across diverse demographic groups, its integration into the social fabric carried profound significance.

The adaptations made by #MeToo to sustain the feminist movement under restrictive conditions came at considerable cost. While the internet enabled connection-building without relying on core leadership and organizational resources, this resulted in diluted social capital and increased vulnerability to preemptive repression and online violence. The framing centered on women's emotional experiences possessed powerful mobilizing potential, yet the absence of emotional management (Ruiz-Junco, 2007, 2013) in the movement led to emotional fluctuations, while also depleting energy through internal and external affective conflicts. As collective advocacy became increasingly difficult to organize, the movement's repertoire became progressively limited to mobilizing around few of the most popular cases, growing more transient and opportunistic, with the tendency for debate to replace real action. The period witnessed an ascending and inspiring movement that nonetheless was fragile and fraught with insecurity.

Post-2020, the further intensification of oppression posed greater challenges to the feminist movement. In April 2021, after facing severe cyber-violence and police brutality, the core members of YFA ceased their activism, both in public and in private spheres. The arrest and enforced disappearance of a feminist in January 2022, for attempting to intervene in a prominent women's rights case, demonstrated a state-level intolerance for even individual activism. Meanwhile, private internet connections and public discussions continue to thrive, now concentrating on how individual women can resist patriarchal oppression through personal lifestyle choices. While feminists can still occasionally provoke collective outrage over high-profile sexual harassment cases, the direct conversion of this outrage into action has markedly diminished.

Conclusion

The evolution of China's feminist movement over the past three decades represents a dynamic process of adaptation and transformation within a shifting authoritarian context. Throughout this journey, the movement has strategically leveraged political opportunities and responded to varying political constraints, persistently and flexibly pursuing its goals of social change (Baldez, 2003; Keech-Marx, 2014). From the elite-driven embedded strategies of 1995-2010, to the youth-led public advocacy of Young Feminist Activism (YFA) in 2012-2015, and finally the mass emotional mobilization of #MeToo since 2018, the enduring resilience of China's feminist movement has been remarkable.

Under the rule of the Party-state system, the movement sought a precarious balance between legitimacy and efficiency, negotiating its autonomy while seeking possible tangible and intangible resources. During the reform era, relative decentralization and the state's eagerness for developmental investment created opportunities for scholar-activists at the system's margins to advocate for reforms, often by leveraging institutional connections and international resources. As feminism was increasingly pushed out of formal structures, a younger generation embraced a growing civil society in more independent ways. Benefiting from media marketization, they amplified their demands and held the government accountable. The transition to centralized and repressive governance brought unprecedented challenges. Civil society became criminalized, surveillance intensified, and political stigmatization increased. Yet, the movement adapted, embracing the internet to decentralize its networks and sustain emotional and narrative-driven mobilizations. While significantly expanding public visibility, the latest stage also introduced new vulnerabilities including fragmentation, reliance on spontaneous mobilization, and exposure to digital surveillance. At every stage, activists grounded themselves in their sociopolitical positioning, redefining women's rights, reformulating goals, and restructuring strategies.

The movement always carried limitations, costs, and risks. How could the movement strategically utilize gender relations and hierarchies without substantially reinforcing them? How could it connect with the masses while maintaining its critical agenda (Liao & Luqiu,

2022)? How could it avoid co-optation while engaging with and utilizing bureaucratic systems (Beckwith, 2000)? feminist activists in any period had ready answers to these challenging questions. They could only accumulate knowledge through continuous experimentation, mutual learning and competition, reflection and improvement, from which movement strategies were gradually derived. The feminist movement's trajectory has not followed a linear path. Nonetheless, it has accumulated significant gains: it has dramatically expanded the feminist community base, reshaped many women's self-perception and identity, and contributed to broader public consciousness-raising and cultural and societal transformations. Despite achieving some policy changes, the movement has never been able to transform the political power structure and remained too weak to negotiate with the state over its operational space.

As the door to reform under authoritarianism closes, the future of China's feminist movement remains uncertain. Yet this uncertainty also contains possibilities. By breaking away from binary perspectives of compromise versus resistance, progress versus regression, and success versus failure, China's feminist movement reveals what can be achieved in the nuanced and enduring struggle for gender equality under the constraints of authoritarian politics.

References:

- Amenta, E., Caren, N., Chiarello, E., & Su, Y. (2010). The political consequences of social movements. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 36(1), 287-307.
- Beckwith, K. (2000). Beyond compare? Women's movements in comparative perspective. *European Journal of Political Research*, 37(4), 431-468.
- Beckwith, K. (2007). Mapping strategic engagements: Women's movements and the state. *International Feminist Journal of Politics*, 9(3), 312-338.
- Brussevich, M., Dabla-Norris, E., & Li, B. (2021). China's rebalancing and gender inequality. *International Monetary Fund*.
- Cai, Y. (2020). *Collective resistance in China: Why popular protests succeed or fail*. Stanford University Press.
- Cai, Y., Feng, Y., & Guo, Y. (2020). The women's media watch network. In P. C. Hsiung, M. Jaschok, & C. Milwertz (Eds.), *Chinese women organizing: Cadres, feminists, Muslims, Queers* (pp. 209–233).

- Cartier, C., & Rothenberg-Aalami, J. (1999). Empowering the “victim”? Gender, development, and women in China under reform. *Journal of Geography*, 98(6), 283-294.
- Chen, X. (2020). Civic and noncivic activism under autocracy: Shifting political space for popular collective action. *Mobilization: An International Quarterly*, 25(SI), 623-640.
- Earl, J. (2015). The future of social movement organizations: The waning dominance of SMOs online. *American Behavioral Scientist*, 59(1), 35-52.
- Fu, D., & Distelhorst, G. (2018). Grassroots participation and repression under Hu Jintao and Xi Jinping. *The China Journal*, 79(1), 100-122.
- Fu, D. (2018). *Mobilizing without the Masses: Control and Contention in China*. Cambridge University Press.
- Fu, H. (2013). Embedded socio-legal activism in China: The case of Yirenping. In D. Marshall (Ed.), *Rethinking law and development* (pp. 159–184). Routledge.
- Gallagher, M. E. (2002). “Reform and openness”: Why China's economic reforms have delayed democracy. *World Politics*, 54(3), 338-372.
- Gelb, J., & Hart, V. (1999). Feminist politics in a hostile environment: Obstacles and opportunities. In M. Giugni, D. McAdam, & C. Tilly (Eds.), *How Social Movements Matter* (pp. 149-181).
- Goodwin, J., & Pfaff, S. (2001). Emotion work in high-risk social movements: Managing fear in the US and East German civil rights movements. In J. Goodwin, J. Jasper, & F. Polletta (Eds.), *Passionate Politics: Emotions and Social Movements* (pp. 282-302).
- Greenhalgh, S. (2001). Fresh winds in Beijing: Chinese feminists speak out on the one-child policy and women's lives. *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society*, 26(3), 847-886.
- Gu, Y., & Heemsbergen, L. (2023). The ambivalent governance of platformed Chinese feminism under censorship: Weibo, Xianzi, and her friends. *International Journal of Communication*, 17-22.
- Gullotta, D., & Lin, L. (2023). In stagnation: A case study of a Chinese community-based labor NGO in the Yangtze River Delta. *Critical Asian Studies*, 55(1), 1-19.
- Gunitsky, S. (2015). Corrupting the cyber-commons: social media as a tool of autocratic stability. *Perspectives on Politics*, 13(1), 42-54.
- Guttenberg, V. (2021). Rice bunnies vs. the river crab: China’s feminists, #Metoo, and networked authoritarianism. *Flux: International Relations Review*, 11(1), 31-39.
- Hildebrandt, T. (2013). *Social organizations and the authoritarian state in China*. Cambridge University Press.

- Ho, P., & Edmonds, R. L. (2008). *China's embedded activism: Opportunities and constraints for a social movement*. Routledge.
- Hsiung, P. C. (2021). Feminist-inspired NGO activism in contemporary China: Expanding the inductive approach in qualitative inquiry. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 27(8–9), 958–976.
- Huang, C. L. (2021). #Metoo in East Asia: The politics of speaking out. *Politics & Gender*, 17(3), 483-490.
- Huhe, N., Tang, M., & Chen, J. (2018). Creating democratic citizens: Political effects of the Internet in China. *Political Research Quarterly*, 71(4), 757-771.
- Ivan, F., & Elisa, N. (2018). State repression of Chinese labor NGOs: A chilling effect? *China Journal*, 80, 111-29.
- Jasper, J. M. (2011). Emotions and social movements: Twenty years of theory and research. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 37, 285-303.
- J Johnston, H. (2012). State violence and oppositional protest in high-capacity authoritarian regimes. *International Journal of Conflict and Violence*, 6(1), 55–74.
- Johnston, H. (2019). The dynamics of resistance and rule in high-capacity authoritarian states. In N. Deitelhoff, V. Kempf, J. Pfister, & P. Wallmeier (Eds.), *Rule and resistance beyond the nation state* (pp. 157–177).
- Joshi, S. (2022). Gendered repertoires of contention: Women's resistance, authoritarian state formation, and land grabbing in Cambodia. *International Feminist Journal of Politics*, 24(2), 198-220.
- Keech-Marx, S. (2014). Airing dirty laundry in public: Anti-domestic violence activism in Beijing. In J. Hsu & R. Hasmath (Eds.), *Associations and the Chinese state: Contested spaces* (pp. 175–199). Routledge.
- Leggett, A. (2017). Online civic engagement and the anti-domestic violence movement in China: Shifting norms and influencing law. *VOLUNTAS: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organizations*, 28, 2251-2277.
- Lei, Y. W. (2016). Freeing the press: How field environment explains critical news reporting in China. *American Journal of Sociology*, 122(1), 1-48.
- Li, P., Cho, H., Qin, Y., & Chen, A. (2021). #MeToo as a connective movement: Examining the frames adopted in the anti-sexual harassment movement in China. *Social Science Computer Review*, 39(5), 1030-1049.
- Liao, S., & Luqiu, L. R. (2022). #MeToo in China: The dynamic of digital activism against sexual assault and harassment in higher education. *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society*, 47(3), 741-764.
- Liao, S. (2023). The platformization of misogyny: Popular media, gender politics, and misogyny in China's state-market nexus. *Media, Culture & Society*, 01634437221146905.

- Liao, S. (2024). Unpopular feminism: Popular culture and gender politics in digital China. *Communication and the Public*, 20570473241268066.
- Lichbach, M. I. (1987). Deterrence or escalation? The puzzle of aggregate studies of repression and dissent. *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 31(2), 266-297.
- Lin, C. (2020, August 22). Distant sisters—When survivors meet. *China Digital Times*. Retrieved December 25, 2024, from <https://chinadigitaltimes.net/chinese/653605.html>
- Lin, Z., & Yang, L. (2019). Individual and collective empowerment: Women's voices in the #MeToo movement in China. *Asian Journal of Women's Studies*, 25(1), 117
- Liu, H. (2022). Dissent networks, state repression, and strategic clemency for defection. *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 66(7-8), 1292-1319.
- Lu, J. (2021). The Yirenping experience: Looking back and pushing forward. *Made in China Journal*, 6(1), 96-101.
- Lu, P. (2019, May 1). Finding a voice. *Logic*. Retrieved December 26, 2024, from <https://logicmag.io/china/finding-a-voice/>
- McAdam, D. (2003). Beyond structural analysis: Toward a more dynamic understanding of social movements. In M. Diani, & D. McAdam (Eds.). *Social Movements and Networks: Relational Approaches to Collective Action* (pp. 281-298).
- McAdam, D., Tarrow, S., & Tilly, C. (2003). Dynamics of contention. *Social Movement Studies*, 2(1), 99-102.
- McCammon, H. (2012). Theorizing social movement strategic adaptation. In *The U.S. Women's Jury Movements and Strategic Adaptation: A More Just Verdict* (Cambridge Studies in Contentious Politics, pp. 11-33). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Milwertz, C., & Bu, W. (2007). Non-governmental organising for gender equality in China—Joining a global emancipatory epistemic community. *International Journal of Human Rights*, 11(1-2), 131-149.
- Milwertz, C. (2003). Activism against domestic violence in the People's Republic of China. *Violence Against Women*, 9(6), 630-654.
- Min, D. (2005). Awakening again: Travelling feminism in China in the 1980s. In *Women's Studies International Forum*, Vol. 28, No. 4, 274-288
- Nathan, A. J. (2009). China since Tiananmen: authoritarian impermanence. *Journal of Democracy*, 20(3), 37-40.
- O'Brien, K. J., & Li, L. (2006). *Rightful Resistance in Rural China*. Cambridge University Press.
- O'Brien, K. J. (2023). Neither withdrawal nor resistance: Adapting to increased repression in China. *Modern China*, 49(1), 3-25.
- Repnikova, M., & Fang, K. (2018). Authoritarian participatory persuasion 2.0: Netizens as

- thought work collaborators in China. *Journal of Contemporary China*, 27(113), 763-779.
- Ritter, E. H. (2014). Policy disputes, political survival, and the onset and severity of state repression. *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, 58(1), 143-168.
- Rootes, C. (2013). Discussion: Mobilization and the changing and persistent dynamics of political participation. In Van Stekelenburg, J., Roggeband, C., & Klandermans, B. (Eds.), *The Future of Social Movement Research: Dynamics, Mechanisms, and Processes* (pp. 299-311).
- Ruiz-Junco, N. (2013). Feeling social movements: Theoretical contributions to social movement research on emotions. *Sociology Compass*, 7(1), 45-54.
- Scoggins, S. E. (2021). Rethinking authoritarian resilience and the coercive apparatus. *Comparative Politics*, 53(2), 309-330.
- Spires, A. J. (2011). Contingent symbiosis and civil society in an authoritarian state: Understanding the survival of China's grassroots NGOs. *American Journal of Sociology*, 117(1), 1-45.
- Staggenborg, S., & Taylor, V. (2005). Whatever happened to the women's movement? *Mobilization: An International Quarterly*, 10(1), 37-52.
- Tan, J. (2017). Digital masquerading: Feminist media activism in China. *Crime, Media, Culture*, 13(2), 171-186.
- Tan, J. (2023). *Digital Masquerade: Feminist Rights and Queer Media in China*. NYU Press.
- Tarrow, S. (1998). *Power in Movement*. Cambridge University Press.
- Teets, J. C. (2013). Let Many Civil Societies Bloom: The Rise of Consultative Authoritarianism in China. *The China Quarterly*, 213, 19-38.
- Tian, F., & Chuang, J. (2022). Depoliticizing China's grassroots NGOs: State and civil society as an institutional field of power. *The China Quarterly*, 250, 509-530.
- Wang, D. (2020). Jia, as in Guojia: Building the Chinese family into a filial nationalist project. *China Law and Society Review*, 5(1), 1-32.
- Wang, Q. (2018a). From 'Non-Governmental Organizing' to "outer-system": Feminism and feminist resistance in post-2000 China. *NORA-Nordic Journal of Feminist and Gender Research*, 26(4), 260-277.
- Wang, Q. (2018b). Young feminist activists in present-day China: A new feminist generation? *China Perspectives*, (3), 59-68.
- Wang, Z. (1997). Maoism, feminism, and the UN conference on women: Women's studies research in contemporary China. *Journal of Women's History*, 8(4), 126-152.
- Wang, Z., & Zhang, Y. (2010). Global concepts, local practices: Chinese feminism since the Fourth UN Conference on Women. *Feminist Studies*, 36(1), 40-70.

- Wang, Z. (2018c). Feminist struggles in a changing China. In A. Basu (Ed.), *Women's Movements in the Global Era: The Power of Local Feminisms* (pp.151-181).
- Wei, T. (2020, December 6). The utopia of civil society: An evening with friends of Xianzi. *Huisheng/China Digital Time*. Retrieved December 26, 2024, from <https://goo.su/Lk6zW>
- Wei, W. (2014). Street, behaviour, art: Advocating gender rights and the innovation of a social movement repertoire. *Chinese Journal of Sociology*, 1(2), 279-304.
- Xiao, M. (2015, May 13). China's feminist awakening. *The New York Times*. <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/05/14/opinion/xiao-meili-chinas-feminist-awakening.html>
- Xiao, M. (2019, May 10). Why we're Jingyao Liu's supporters: #I'm not a perfect victim either. *Jianjiaobuluo/Phoenix.Com*. Retrieved December 26, 2024, from <https://goo.su/zQLYEN>
- Xu, F. (2009). Chinese feminisms encounter international feminisms: Identity, power and knowledge production. *International Feminist Journal of Politics*, 11(2), 196–215.
- Yin, S., & Sun, Y. (2021). Intersectional digital feminism: Assessing the participation politics and impact of the MeToo Movement in China. *Feminist Media Studies*, 21(7), 1176-1192.
- Zeng, J. (2020). #MeToo as connective action: A study of the anti-sexual violence and anti-sexual harassment campaign on Chinese social media in 2018. *Journalism Practice*, 14(2), 171-190.
- Zhang, N. (2020). Searching for 'authentic' NGOs: The NGO discourse and women's organizations in China. In P. C. Hsiung, M. Jaschok, & C. Milwertz (Eds.), *Chinese women organizing: Cadres, feminists, Muslims, queers* (pp. 159–190). Routledge.
- Zhu, H., & Lu, J. (2022). The crackdown on rights-advocacy NGOs in Xi's China: Politicizing the law and legalizing the repression. *Journal of Contemporary China*, 31(136), 518-538.